

17

Defense, Endgames, and Failed Attacks

How to stop Black's counterplay, convert space after queens come off, and recover when the king attack does not land.



THIS VOLUME

6

deep lessons

12

lesson positions

30

course pages

You will keep playing coherent chess after the opening story changes and turn attacking space into endgame assets.

LEARN THE STRUCTURE, THEN THE LINE

A four-pass method for a theory-heavy opening

1. DECODE THE POSITION

Read the board before the moves. Name the center, each side's break, the worst piece, the king-safety difference, and the race clock.

2. UNDERSTAND THE CAUSAL CHAIN

Every recommendation connects a cue to a reason and a consequence. If you know only the move, you do not yet know the opening.

3. PLAY THE DECISION

Generate White's candidates, find Black's strongest reply, and choose the resulting structure you understand. The move is the end of the reasoning, not the beginning.

4. RETRIEVE UNDER PRESSURE

Cover the answer key, reconstruct the line, and speak the memory rule. Review after 1, 3, 7, 14, and 30 days, then test the idea in a slow game.

THEORY WARNING

This is a durable concept-first repertoire, not a claim to be a live engine database. Before tournament use, verify sharp forcing branches in Fritz or a current database.

Priority order at the board: legality and tactical survival, king safety, forcing moves, central transformation, activity, structure, then the remembered rule.

SIX LINKED LESSONS

Recognition first, execution second

LESSON 097 | PAGE 4

Decode: Meeting queenside counterplay*Defend the opposite wing only when the move removes a forcing threat or creates your own resource.*

LESSON 098 | PAGE 8

Play: Meeting queenside counterplay*Defend the opposite wing only when the move removes a forcing threat or creates your own resource.*

LESSON 099 | PAGE 12

Decode: Trading queens with an e5 space edge*When queens leave, convert attacking space into piece activity and outposts.*

LESSON 100 | PAGE 16

Play: Trading queens with an e5 space edge*When queens leave, convert attacking space into piece activity and outposts.*

LESSON 101 | PAGE 20

Decode: Repairing an overextended kingside*When an attack expires, save the king and structure before starting a second operation.*

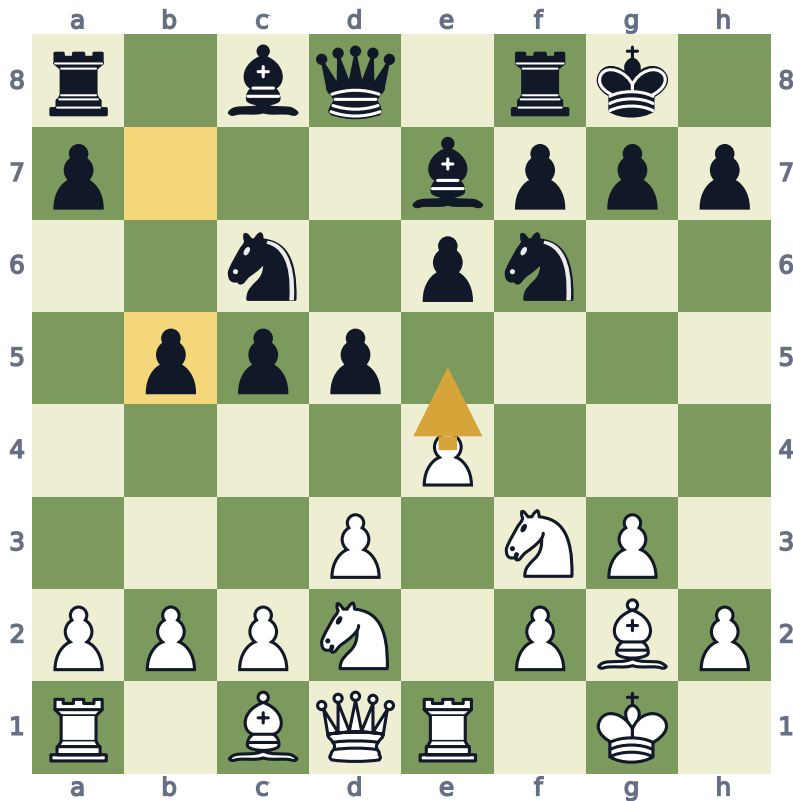
LESSON 102 | PAGE 24

Play: Repairing an overextended kingside*When an attack expires, save the king and structure before starting a second operation.***VOLUME OBJECTIVE**

You will keep playing coherent chess after the opening story changes and turn attacking space into endgame assets.

DECODE PASS | STRUCTURAL DECISION POINT

Decode: Meeting queenside counterplay



WHY THIS POSITION MATTERS

A timely a3 can question b4 and prevent Black from fixing the queenside, but it also spends an attacking tempo and may open the a-file.

DECISION RULE

What happens after each black pawn response, and does White gain a useful file or merely another weakness?

SIDE TO MOVE

White

BLACK'S COUNTERPLAY

Black chooses ...bxa3, ...b3, or maintaining tension according to which file and target benefits the queenside pieces.

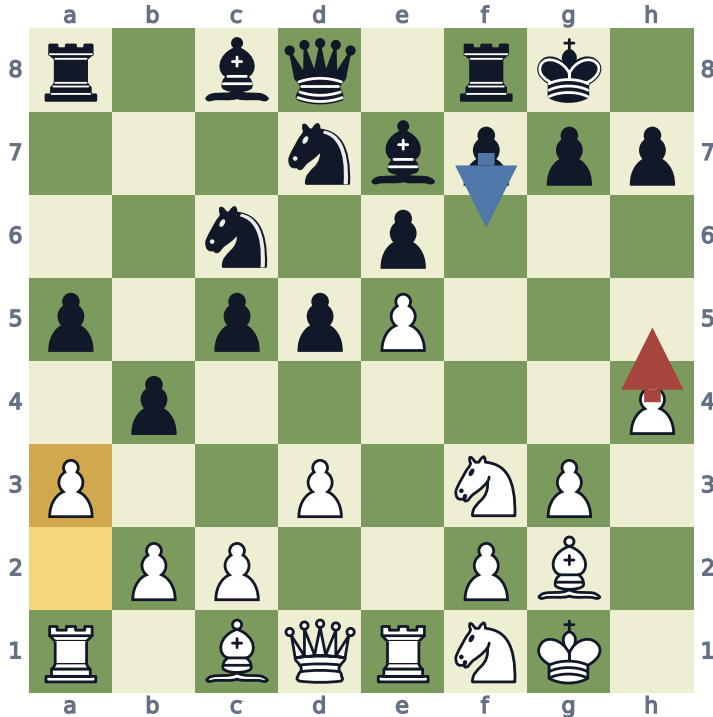
WHITE'S PLAN

White intervenes only when the queenside move protects d3, preserves a knight route, or removes a concrete threat.

MEMORY RULE | Defend the opposite wing only when the move removes a forcing threat or creates your own resource.

CUE -> REASON -> MOVE -> REPLY -> NEW POSITION

The plan map



CUE

A timely a3 can question b4 and prevent Black from fixing the queenside, but it also spends an attacking tempo and may open the a-file.

BLACK AIMS FOR

Black chooses ...bxa3, ...b3, or maintaining tension according to which file and target benefits the queenside pieces.

FINAL SIDE TO MOVE

Black

WHITE'S BEST PRACTICAL PLAN

White intervenes only when the queenside move protects d3, preserves a knight route, or removes a concrete threat.

FAILURE MODE

Stopping every pawn advance while the kingside initiative disappears.

DECISION TEST

Ask: What happens after each black pawn response, and does White gain a useful file or merely another weakness? Then compare at least two White candidates against Black's strongest forcing reply. Choose the endpoint whose center, king safety, and piece jobs you can explain.

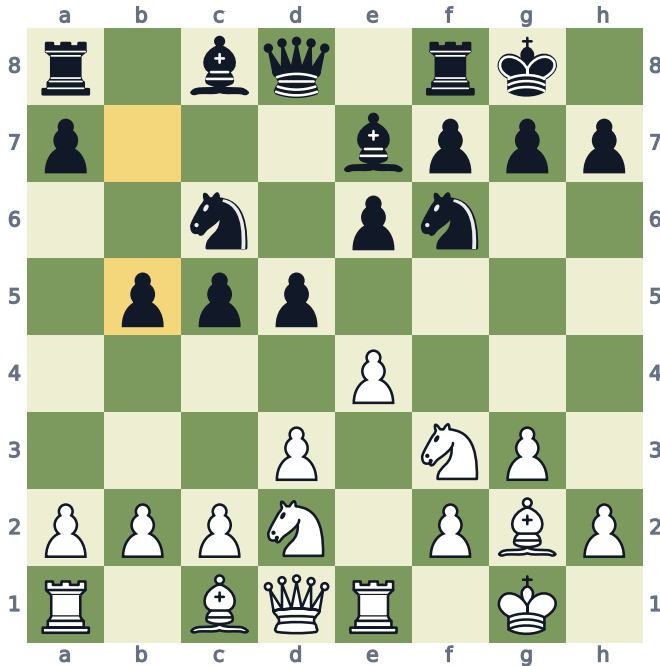
RULE | Defend the opposite wing only when the move removes a forcing threat or creates your own resource.

INSTRUCTIVE REFERENCE LINE - NOT A PROMISE OF FORCED BEST PLAY

Move-by-move meaning

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 e6 2. d3 d5 3. Nd2 Nf6 4. Ngf3 Be7 5. g3 O-O 6. Bg2 c5 7. O-O Nc6 8. Re1 b5 9. e5 Nd7 10. h4 a5 11. Nf1 b4 12. a3



- Bg2: White changes a bishop's diagonal; identify the pawn break that will make the diagonal useful.
- c5: Black attacks d4 and accelerates queenside expansion.
- O-O: White secures the king and activates a rook; the center can now close or open with less tactical risk.
- Nc6: Black reroutes a knight to c6; name the destination job and the useful move conceded to the opponent.
- Re1: White places a rook behind a pawn break or file expected to open.
- b5: Black gains queenside space and begins the race against White's king attack.

WHAT THE LINE TEACHES

A timely a3 can question b4 and prevent Black from fixing the queenside, but it also spends an attacking tempo and may open the a-file.

WHAT MUST BE CALCULATED

What happens after each black pawn response, and does White gain a useful file or merely another weakness? White's attacking or positional plan is: White intervenes only when the queenside move protects d3, preserves a knight route, or removes a concrete threat. The line fails as a template when: Stopping every pawn advance while the kingside initiative disappears.

STORE THIS | Defend the opposite wing only when the move removes a forcing threat or creates your own resource.

COVER THE ANSWER KEY AND SPEAK EACH ANSWER

Retrieval and self-coaching

1. What center or structural transition defines this position?

2. What is Black's most urgent counterplay, and which pawn break enables it?

3. What is White's primary plan, and which piece or pawn makes it work?

4. What exact question decides the next move?

5. What is the most dangerous way to misuse the remembered plan?

ANSWER KEY

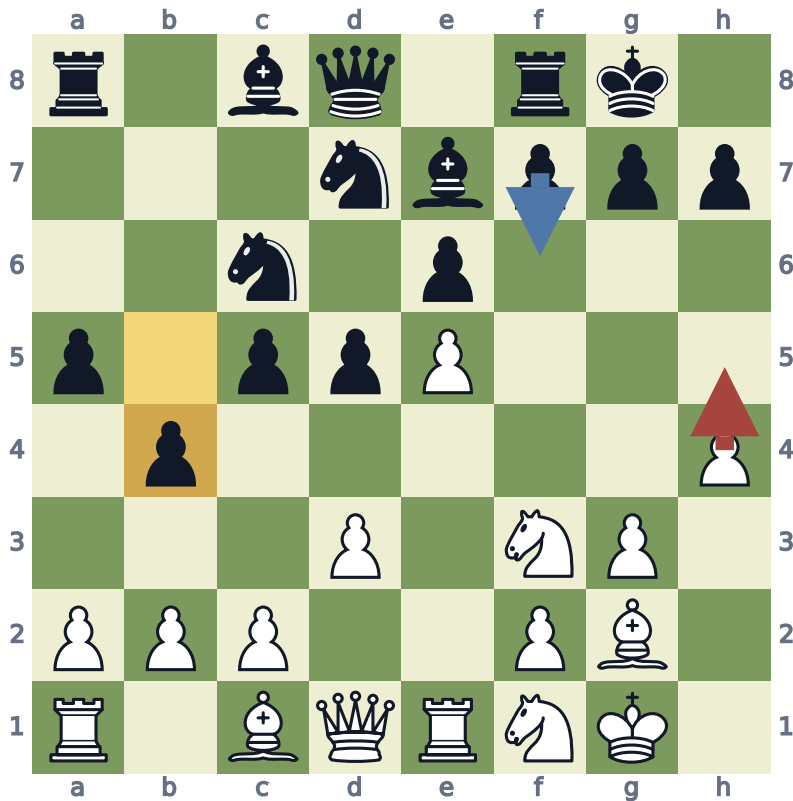
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BOARD RECONSTRUCTION

Rebuild the position after 16 plies from memory, then replay: 6. Bg2 c5 7. O-O Nc6 8. Re1 b5

PLAY PASS | PLAN EXECUTION AND TACTICAL CONTACT

Play: Meeting queenside counterplay



WHY THIS POSITION MATTERS

A timely a3 can question b4 and prevent Black from fixing the queenside, but it also spends an attacking tempo and may open the a-file.

DECISION RULE

What happens after each black pawn response, and does White gain a useful file or merely another weakness?

SIDE TO MOVE

White

BLACK'S COUNTERPLAY

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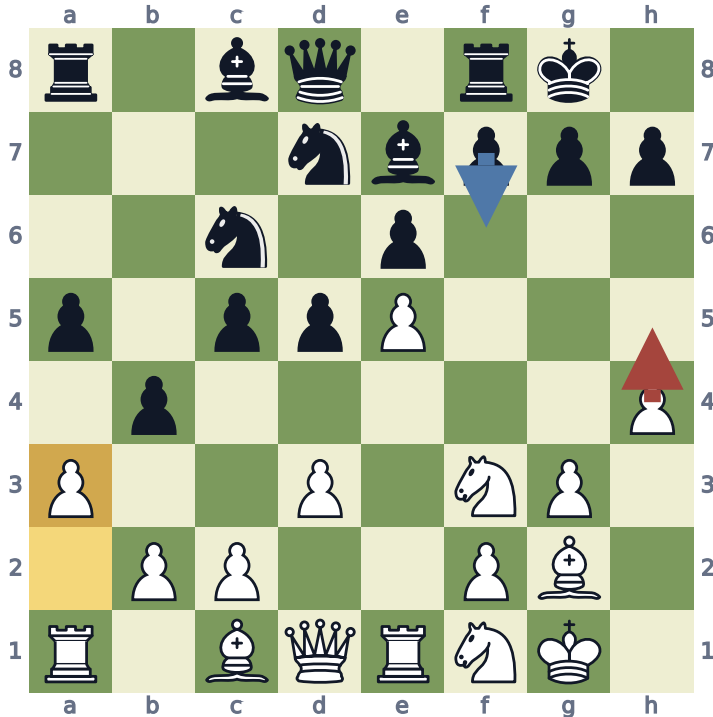
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CUE -> REASON -> MOVE -> REPLY -> NEW POSITION

The plan map



CUE

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BLACK AIMS FOR

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FINAL SIDE TO MOVE

Black

WHITE'S BEST PRACTICAL PLAN

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FAILURE MODE

Stopping every pawn advance while the kingside initiative disappears.

DECISION TEST

Ask: What happens after each black pawn response, and does White gain a useful file or merely another weakness? Then compare at least two White candidates against Black's strongest forcing reply. Choose the endpoint whose center, king safety, and piece jobs you can explain.

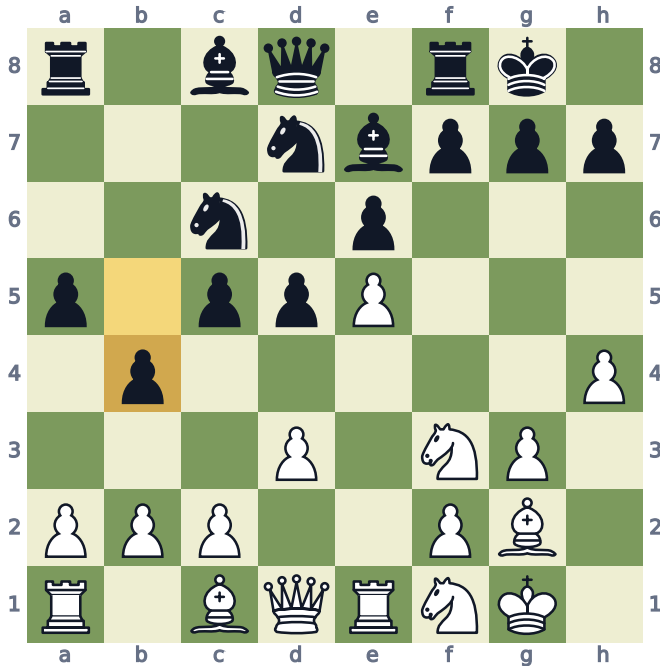
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Move-by-move meaning

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- e5: White gains kingside space and drives the f6 knight while fixing a pawn-chain target.
- Nd7: Black reroutes a knight to d7; name the destination job and the useful move conceded to the opponent.
- h4: White creates a possible kingside hook and supports h5.
- a5: Black changes the pawn skeleton; reassess the chain, breaks, weak squares, and king exposure.
- Nf1: White reroutes a knight to f1; name the destination job and the useful move conceded to the opponent.
- b4: Black changes the pawn skeleton; reassess the chain, breaks, weak squares, and king exposure.

WHAT THE LINE TEACHES

A timely a3 can question b4 and prevent Black from fixing the queenside, but it also spends an attacking tempo and may open the a-file.

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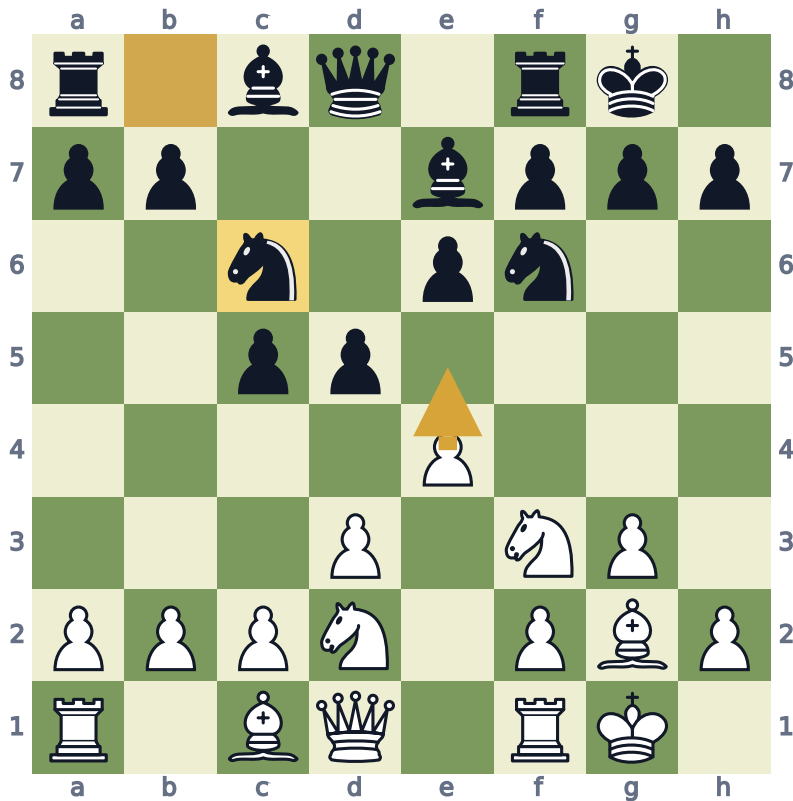
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BOARD RECONSTRUCTION

Rebuild the position after 22 plies from memory, then replay: 9. e5 Nd7 10. h4 a5 11. Nf1 b4

DECODE PASS | STRUCTURAL DECISION POINT

Decode: Trading queens with an e5 space edge



WHY THIS POSITION MATTERS

If queens come off, the e5 pawn can remain a space asset that restricts knights, but its attacking value disappears and its maintenance cost becomes central.

DECISION RULE

After a queen trade, which white piece gains a square because e5 restricts Black, and which pawn becomes a target?

SIDE TO MOVE

White

BLACK'S COUNTERPLAY

Black attacks e5 and d3, exchanges the best blockader or defender, and uses queenside space in the endgame.

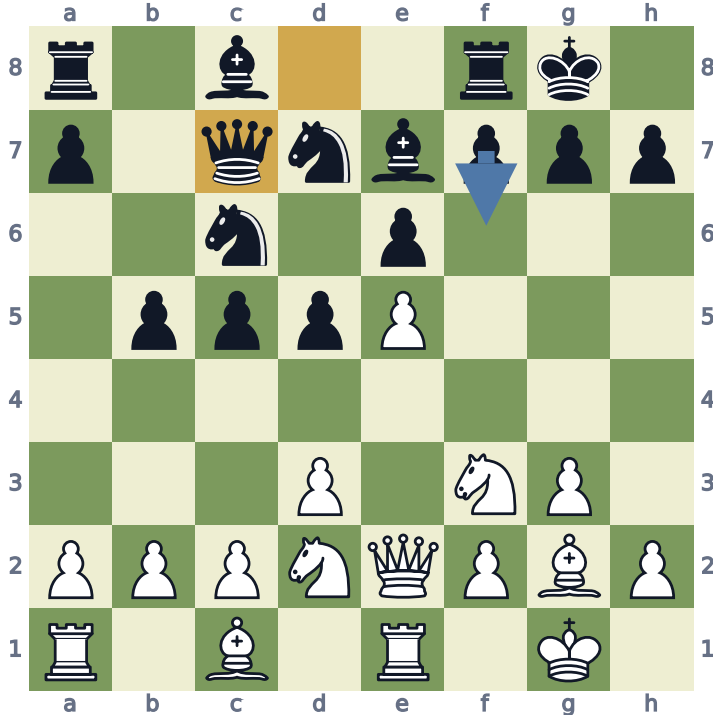
WHITE'S PLAN

White uses the space to improve knights, gains an outpost, and avoids defending the pawn with every piece.

MEMORY RULE | When queens leave, convert attacking space into piece activity and outposts.

CUE -> REASON -> MOVE -> REPLY -> NEW POSITION

The plan map



CUE

If queens come off, the e5 pawn can remain a space asset that restricts knights, but its attacking value disappears and its maintenance cost becomes central.

BLACK AIMS FOR

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FINAL SIDE TO MOVE

White

WHITE'S BEST PRACTICAL PLAN

White uses the space to improve knights, gains an outpost, and avoids defending the pawn with every piece.

FAILURE MODE

Rejecting a sound queen trade because the opening was supposed to produce an attack.

DECISION TEST

Ask: After a queen trade, which white piece gains a square because e5 restricts Black, and which pawn becomes a target? Then compare at least two White candidates against Black's strongest forcing reply. Choose the endpoint whose center, king safety, and piece jobs you can explain.

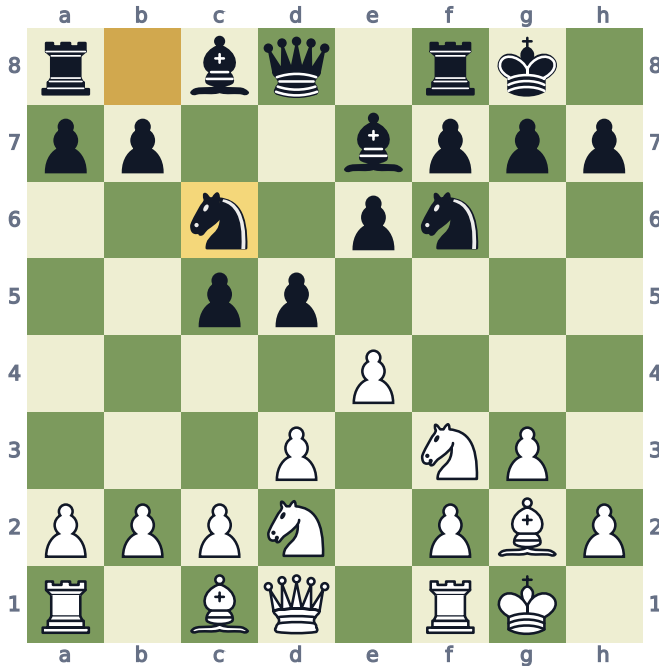
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- g3: White changes the pawn skeleton; reassess the chain, breaks, weak squares, and king exposure.
- O-O: Black secures the king and activates a rook; the center can now close or open with less tactical risk.
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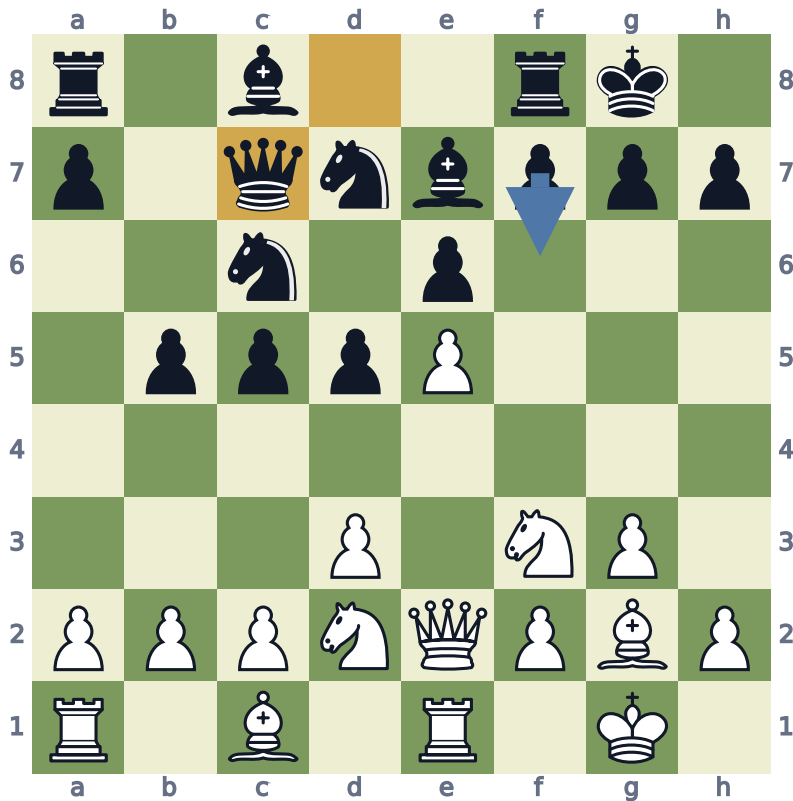
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BOARD RECONSTRUCTION

Rebuild the position after 14 plies from memory, then replay: 5. g3 O-O 6. Bg2 c5 7. O-O Nc6

PLAY PASS | PLAN EXECUTION AND TACTICAL CONTACT

Play: Trading queens with an e5 space edge



WHY THIS POSITION MATTERS

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DECISION RULE

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SIDE TO MOVE

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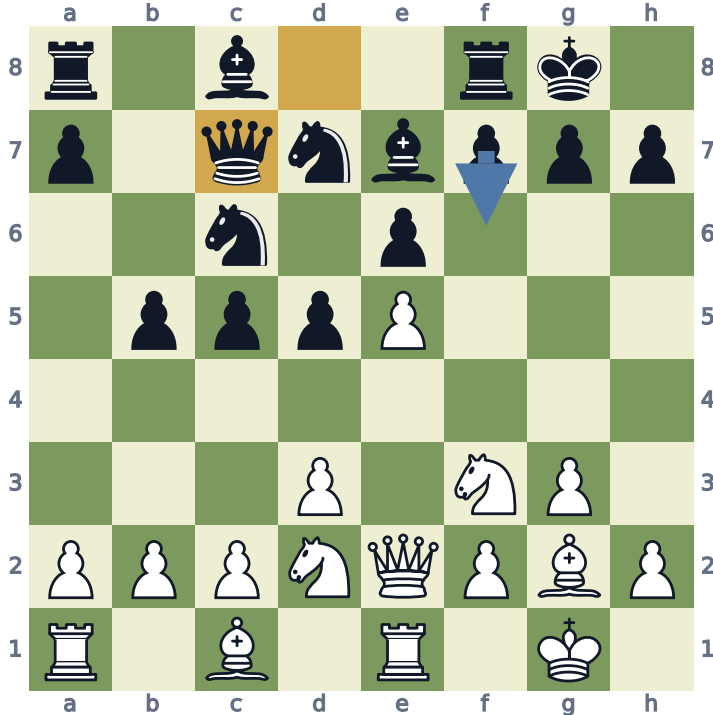
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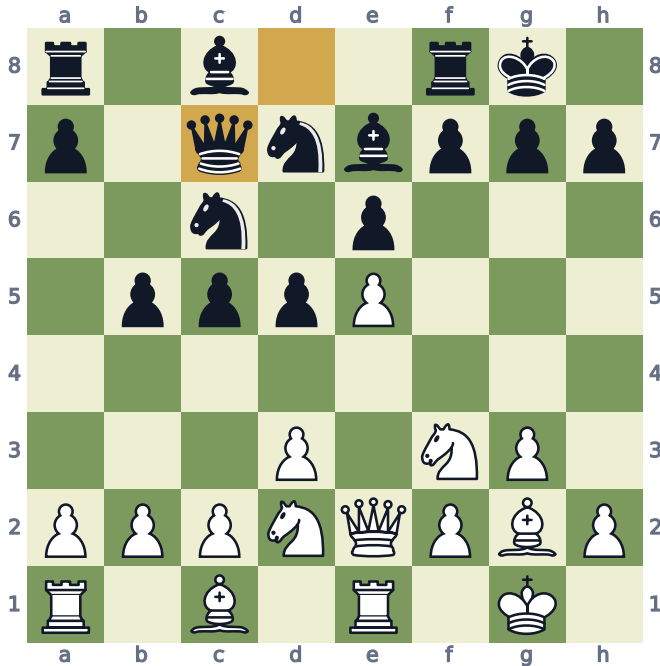
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INSTRUCTIVE REFERENCE LINE - NOT A PROMISE OF FORCED BEST PLAY

Move-by-move meaning

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- Re1: White places a rook behind a pawn break or file expected to open.
- b5: Black gains queenside space and begins the race against White's king attack.
- e5: White gains kingside space and drives the f6 knight while fixing a pawn-chain target.
- Nd7: Black reroutes a knight to d7; name the destination job and the useful move conceded to the opponent.
- Qe2: White coordinates center and wing plans, but must check whether the queen becomes a tempo target.
- Qc7: Black coordinates center and wing plans, but must check whether the queen becomes a tempo target.

WHAT THE LINE TEACHES

If queens come off, the e5 pawn can remain a space asset that restricts knights, but its attacking value disappears and its maintenance cost becomes central.

WHAT MUST BE CALCULATED

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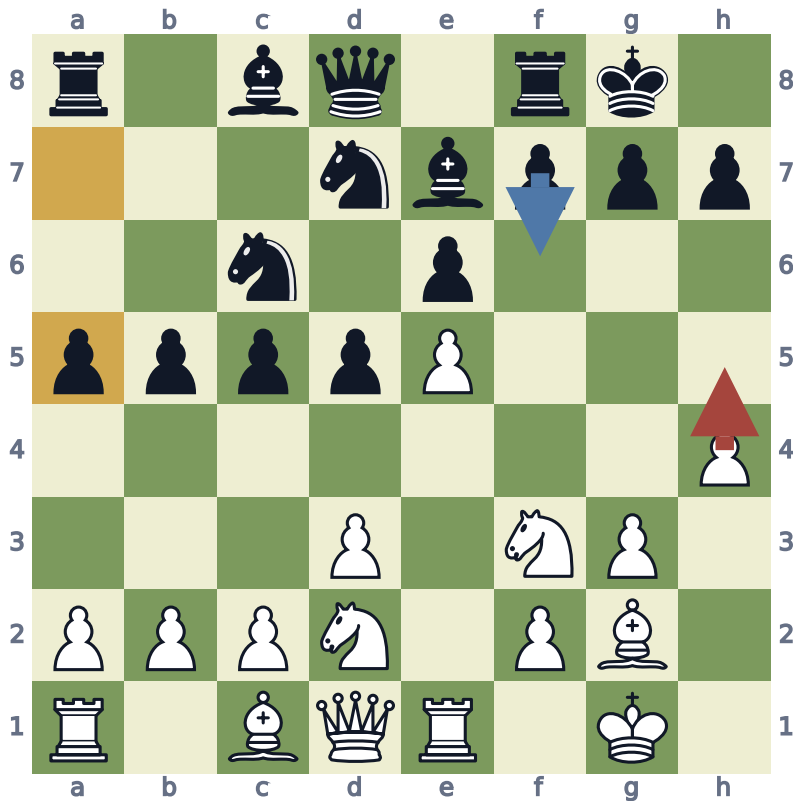
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BOARD RECONSTRUCTION

Rebuild the position after 20 plies from memory, then replay: 8. Re1 b5 9. e5 Nd7 10. Qe2 Qc7

DECODE PASS | STRUCTURAL DECISION POINT

Decode: Repairing an overextended kingside



WHY THIS POSITION MATTERS

If the attack stalls, f4, g4, and h4 can become targets around White's own king; the correct plan may be consolidation and central simplification.

DECISION RULE

Which pawn cannot be defended economically, and what exchange reduces Black's attacking force most?

SIDE TO MOVE

White

BLACK'S COUNTERPLAY

Black opens lines with ...f6, attacks d3, and transfers pieces toward the weakened white king.

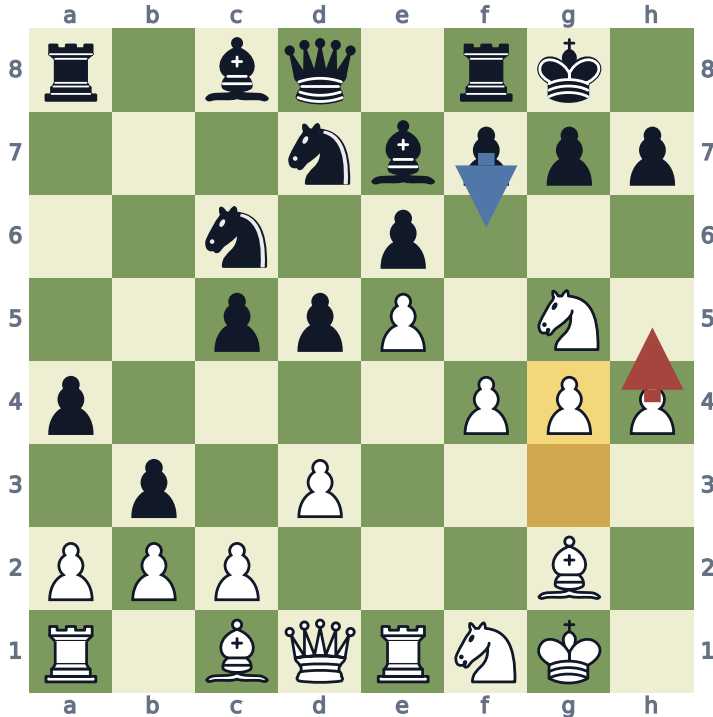
WHITE'S PLAN

White closes dangerous files, trades attackers, and uses the space to stabilize before seeking a second break.

MEMORY RULE | When an attack expires, save the king and structure before starting a second operation.

CUE -> REASON -> MOVE -> REPLY -> NEW POSITION

The plan map



CUE

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BLACK AIMS FOR

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FINAL SIDE TO MOVE

Black

WHITE'S BEST PRACTICAL PLAN

White closes dangerous files, trades attackers, and uses the space to stabilize before seeking a second break.

FAILURE MODE

Continuing to push because retreat feels inconsistent with the original plan.

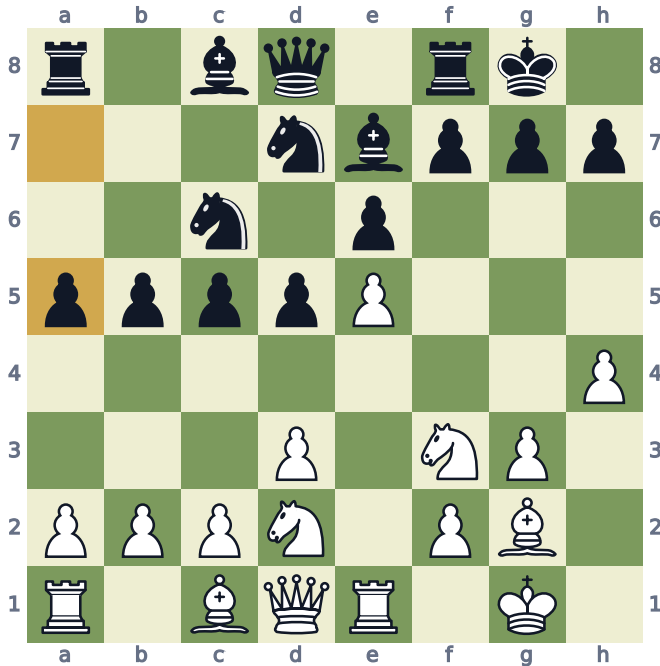
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Which pawn cannot be defended economically, and what exchange reduces Black's attacking force most? White's attacking or positional plan is: White closes dangerous files, trades attackers, and uses the space to stabilize before seeking a second break. The line fails as a template when: Continuing to push because retreat feels inconsistent with the original plan.

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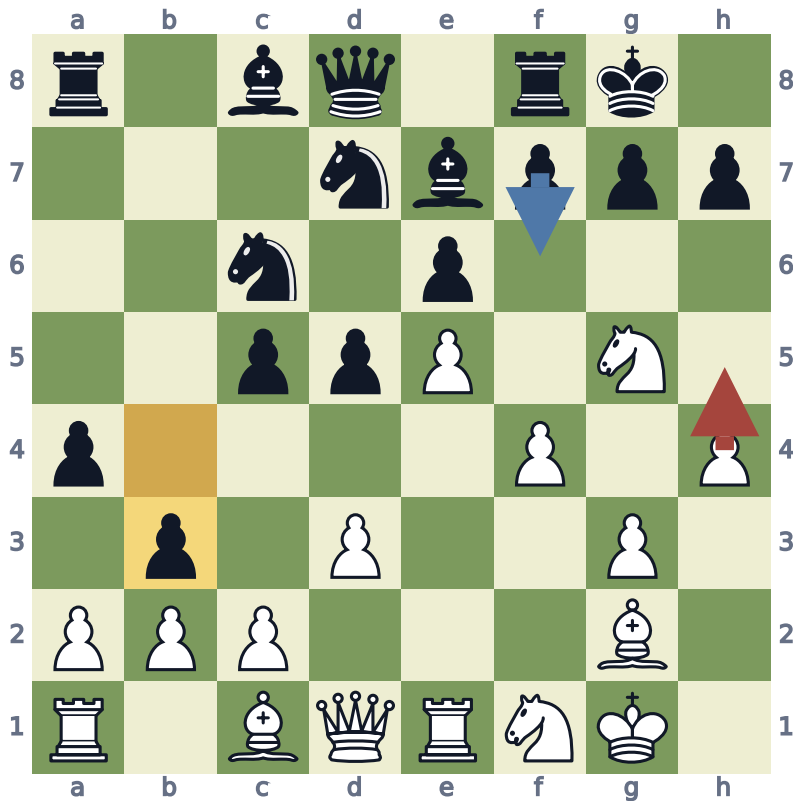
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BOARD RECONSTRUCTION

Rebuild the position after 20 plies from memory, then replay: 8. Re1 b5 9. e5 Nd7 10. h4 a5

PLAY PASS | PLAN EXECUTION AND TACTICAL CONTACT

Play: Repairing an overextended kingside



WHY THIS POSITION MATTERS

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SIDE TO MOVE

White

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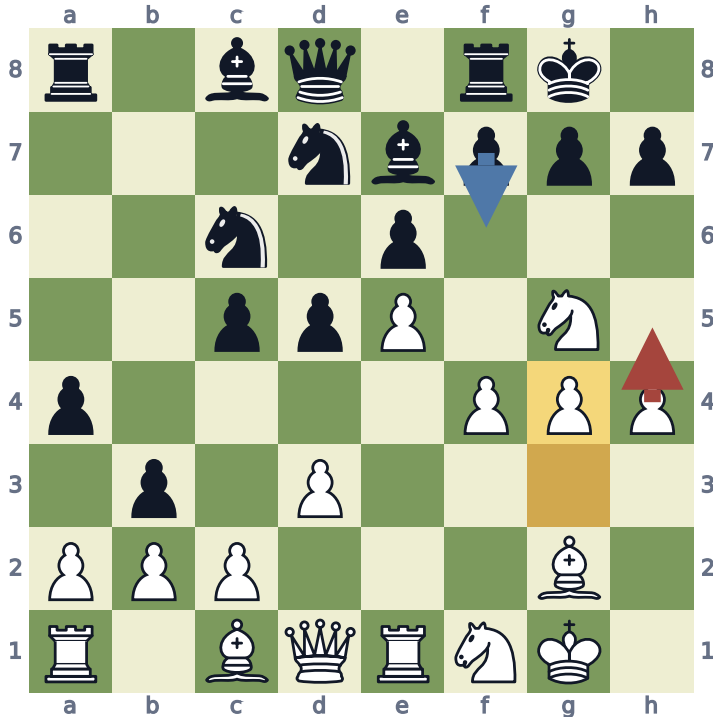
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FINAL SIDE TO MOVE

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Continuing to push because retreat feels inconsistent with the original plan.

DECISION TEST

Ask: Which pawn cannot be defended economically, and what exchange reduces Black's attacking force most? Then compare at least two White candidates against Black's strongest forcing reply. Choose the endpoint whose center, king safety, and piece jobs you can explain.

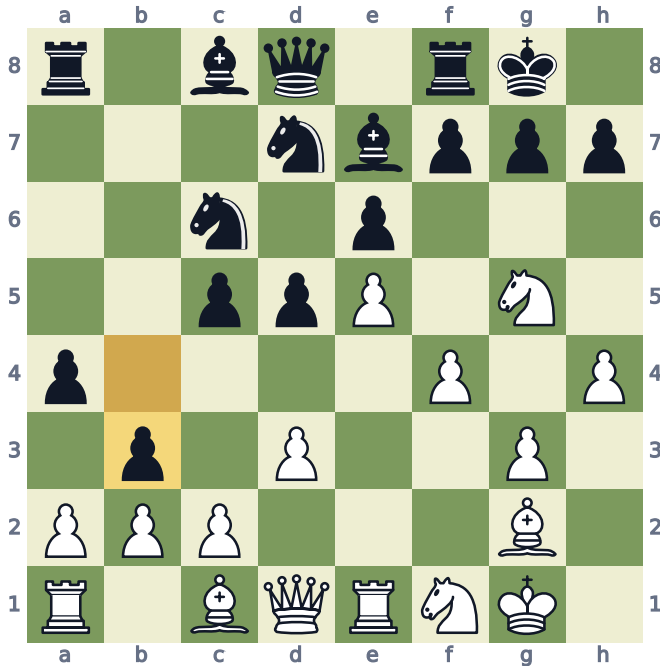
RULE | When an attack expires, save the king and structure before starting a second operation.

INSTRUCTIVE REFERENCE LINE - NOT A PROMISE OF FORCED BEST PLAY

Move-by-move meaning

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 e6 2. d3 d5 3. Nd2 Nf6 4. Ngf3 Be7 5. g3 O-O 6. Bg2 c5 7. O-O Nc6 8. Re1 b5 9. e5 Nd7 10. h4 a5 11. Nf1 b4 12. Ng5 a4 13. f4 b3 14. g4



- Nf1: White reroutes a knight to f1; name the destination job and the useful move conceded to the opponent.
- b4: Black changes the pawn skeleton; reassess the chain, breaks, weak squares, and king exposure.
- Ng5: White reroutes a knight to g5; name the destination job and the useful move conceded to the opponent.
- a4: Black changes the pawn skeleton; reassess the chain, breaks, weak squares, and king exposure.
- f4: White supports e5 and prepares contact on f5 while loosening the king.
- b3: Black changes the pawn skeleton; reassess the chain, breaks, weak squares, and king exposure.

WHAT THE LINE TEACHES

If the attack stalls, f4, g4, and h4 can become targets around White's own king; the correct plan may be consolidation and central simplification.

WHAT MUST BE CALCULATED

Which pawn cannot be defended economically, and what exchange reduces Black's attacking force most? White's attacking or positional plan is: White closes dangerous files, trades attackers, and uses the space to stabilize before seeking a second break. The line fails as a template when: Continuing to push because retreat feels inconsistent with the original plan.

STORE THIS | When an attack expires, save the king and structure before starting a second operation.

COVER THE ANSWER KEY AND SPEAK EACH ANSWER

Retrieval and self-coaching

1. What center or structural transition defines this position?

2. What is Black's most urgent counterplay, and which pawn break enables it?

3. What is White's primary plan, and which piece or pawn makes it work?

4. What exact question decides the next move?

5. What is the most dangerous way to misuse the remembered plan?

ANSWER KEY

1. If the attack stalls, f4, g4, and h4 can become targets around White's own king; the correct plan may be consolidation and central simplification. 2. Black opens lines with ...f6, attacks d3, and transfers pieces toward the weakened white king. 3. White closes dangerous files, trades attackers, and uses the space to stabilize before seeking a second break. 4. Which pawn cannot be defended economically, and what exchange reduces Black's attacking force most? 5. Continuing to push because retreat feels inconsistent with the original plan.

BOARD RECONSTRUCTION

Rebuild the position after 26 plies from memory, then replay: 11. Nf1 b4 12. Ng5 a4 13. f4 b3

SIX-POSITION TEST

Can you retrieve the plan without the chapter?

LESSON 097 Decode: Meeting queenside counterplay

Prompt: What happens after each black pawn response, and does White gain a useful file or merely another weakness?

Recall: Defend the opposite wing only when the move removes a forcing threat or creates your own resource.

LESSON 098 Play: Meeting queenside counterplay

Prompt: What happens after each black pawn response, and does White gain a useful file or merely another weakness?

Recall: Defend the opposite wing only when the move removes a forcing threat or creates your own resource.

LESSON 099 Decode: Trading queens with an e5 space edge

Prompt: After a queen trade, which white piece gains a square because e5 restricts Black, and which pawn becomes a target?

Recall: When queens leave, convert attacking space into piece activity and outposts.

LESSON 100 Play: Trading queens with an e5 space edge

Prompt: After a queen trade, which white piece gains a square because e5 restricts Black, and which pawn becomes a target?

Recall: When queens leave, convert attacking space into piece activity and outposts.

LESSON 101 Decode: Repairing an overextended kingside

Prompt: Which pawn cannot be defended economically, and what exchange reduces Black's attacking force most?

Recall: When an attack expires, save the king and structure before starting a second operation.

LESSON 102 Play: Repairing an overextended kingside

Prompt: Which pawn cannot be defended economically, and what exchange reduces Black's attacking force most?

Recall: When an attack expires, save the king and structure before starting a second operation.

PASS STANDARD

For each position: name the structure, Black's counterplay, White's plan, one candidate, the strongest reply, and the failure mode. Score one point each; 30 of 36 is a pass.

THREE SCENARIOS TO STORE

One-page repertoire memory sheet

CARD 1

Meeting queenside counterplay

1. e4 e6 2. d3 d5 3. Nd2 Nf6 4. Ngf3 Be7 5. g3 O-O 6. Bg2 c5 7. O-O Nc6 8. Re1 b5 9. e5 Nd7 10. h4 a5 11. Nf1 b4 12. a3

Decision: What happens after each black pawn response, and does White gain a useful file or merely another weakness?

Memory: Defend the opposite wing only when the move removes a forcing threat or creates your own resource.

CARD 2

Trading queens with an e5 space edge

1. e4 e6 2. d3 d5 3. Nd2 Nf6 4. Ngf3 Be7 5. g3 O-O 6. Bg2 c5 7. O-O Nc6 8. Re1 b5 9. e5 Nd7 10. Qe2 Qc7

Decision: After a queen trade, which white piece gains a square because e5 restricts Black, and which pawn becomes a target?

Memory: When queens leave, convert attacking space into piece activity and outposts.

CARD 3

Repairing an overextended kingside

1. e4 e6 2. d3 d5 3. Nd2 Nf6 4. Ngf3 Be7 5. g3 O-O 6. Bg2 c5 7. O-O Nc6 8. Re1 b5 9. e5 Nd7 10. h4 a5 11. Nf1 b4 12. Ng5 a4 13. f4 b3 14. g4

Decision: Which pawn cannot be defended economically, and what exchange reduces Black's attacking force most?

Memory: When an attack expires, save the king and structure before starting a second operation.

Reconstruct each card from the final position, then from the opening moves alone.

SPACED RETRIEVAL AND GAME TRANSFER

Volume mastery tracker

Lesson	D1	D3	D7	D14	D30	Game	Pass
097 Decode: Meeting queenside counterplay	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
098 Play: Meeting queenside counterplay	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
099 Decode: Trading queens with an e5 space edge	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
100 Play: Trading queens with an e5 space edge	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
101 Decode: Repairing an overextended kingside	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
102 Play: Repairing an overextended kingside	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

TWELVE-WEEK CYCLE

Weeks 1-2: decode the three structures. Weeks 3-4: replay all lines from memory. Weeks 5-7: solve the workbook pages. Weeks 8-10: test in slow games or against Fritz. Weeks 11-12: analyze failures and retest the volume examination.

PROMOTION RULE

Advance only when you can explain every memory rule, reproduce the three reference lines, name Black's strongest counterplay, and show at least one analyzed game where the decision appeared.

Do not measure mastery by pages completed. Measure whether the correct questions appear during a real game.